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Budget photo printers

With Diwali just round the corner, a lot of festive photos will be clicked. Here's what to do if you're scouting a photo printer

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It has been sometime since I took a proper look at buying photo printers, and it's mainly due to two reasons: 1) MFPs or multi-function printers have cannibalized and eaten into the single-function printer space, and 2) nothing much seems to be going on in the single-function printers at the budget end of the spectrum, and we're talking about photo printers that cost less than ₹10,000. Printers aren't seeing new products launched day in and day out like smartphones, tablets and ultrabooks, for instance. Printers aren't hot anymore, they're dull and boring boxes, not as exciting as some other obvious products. However, they serve a purpose and for this reason alone I shan't ignore them wholly. We'll be only discussing A4 printers in the space below, for I don't know how many of you are really looking at A3 printers for home use – if many of you are, I might review some of them just to let you know which one to buy.

When we last looked at photo printers selling under ₹10,000 in a comparison test, several months ago, we declared the Canon Pixma iP4870 as the Best

Performer, while the HP Officejet e609a bagged the Best Buy award. The Canon photo printer was easily the best, with photo prints that reproduced skin tones and glow extremely well. Images had just the right level of colour saturation, gradients were smooth, reflections and shadows were believable, and the overall photos were very good for home use. Now, Canon officially doesn't list the printer on its website anymore, nor does it manufacture it, but I'd still like to say that you should buy this printer (if you



MFCJ625DW Brother

just need a photo printer for your home) if you stumble across it forgotten under a heap in some IT shop in Lamington Road, SP Road, or Nehru Place – not only will it be much cheaper than last year's price, it'll be still worth your

money. Trust me, printer technology hasn't improved by leaps and bounds to suddenly render obsolete the best performing photo printer from last year – no way. So yeah, keep an eye out for these bargains.

The other option, which is in keeping with marketing realities and availability of products, is to just opt for a multi-function printer within that budget (10k), one that's hopefully good at printing photos. Of all the colour inkjet multi-function printers we've reviewed this year, I'd like to bring into focus two products in particular: the Brother MFC-J625DW and Canon Pixma E510. Not only do these MFPs have solid photocopying and scanning abilities, their inkjet cartridges when paired with the right type of paper produce some of the best photo prints you can expect to get out of an MFP selling under ₹10,000. Not only is the total cost of ownership of the Brother MFC-J625DW lower and more economical than most of its competitors, but it also offers an array of connectivity features not seen on most of its competitors.

Other than these respectable printers for your home, what if you need a portable, compact printer to carry around on vacations, capable of producing instant prints? While I haven't reviewed it, the Canon Selphy CP900 is one of only two new compact photo printers to launch in this calendar year, alongside the Epson Picturemate PM 245, which I did examine a couple of months ago. However, the reality of both these devices are that they're extremely niche and expensive compared to traditional, table-top photo printers. Go ahead and buy them only if you can't wait to come back home and print your vacation photos.

Oh and don't forget, while you visit retail stores to check printers out in action, some of the best deals and discounts for them are now available online. Ecommerce websites are all the rage right now, and I found out that Flipkart has quite an extensive printer section with up-to-date products; Infibeam and Naaptol, too, for that matter. Definitely scout these ecommerce websites to get the best possible deal for your next photo printer purchase. Good luck!